



▲ **This diorama** or miniature clay model exhibited at the Gandhi Smriti and Darshan Samiti Museum in New Delhi depicts the incident at the Pietermaritzburg railway station in South Africa. This incident influenced him to take up his fight against discrimination.

The Mahatma travels

Gandhi chose the third-class compartment of the railways as his mode of travel. The conditions of travel in the third-class were bleak – a callous bureaucracy, overcrowding, lack of sanitation facilities and hygiene, the practice of social prejudices, and problems concerning railway workers. His unbroken third-class tours during 1915–19 fostered an understanding in his mind of the relationship shared by the institution with the bulk of the Indian population, and gave him insights on his countrymen as well. It was a live metaphor of how the colonial administration treated the natives. He documented the trials of third-class travel in the “Woes of Third Class Passengers”, recalling its inconveniences. By 1918–19, Gandhi had fallen ill and had to stop travelling third class. By the time he could finally resume, he had become the “Mahatma”. Scores of people would flock to every stop of the train in which he was travelling for a glimpse of him.